

FORT BEND COUNTY · RICHMOND · SUGAR LAND · GREATER HOUSTON



Understanding Medicare

A plain-language guide to your options

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Serving Richmond, Sugar Land & the Greater Houston Area, TX

The Four Parts of Medicare

Medicare can feel like alphabet soup at first. Here's what each part actually covers, in plain terms.

Part A	Hospital Insurance	Inpatient hospital stays, skilled nursing facility care, hospice, and some home health care.
Part B	Medical Insurance	Doctor visits, outpatient care, preventive services, durable medical equipment, and some home health care.
Part C	Medicare Advantage	An alternative way to receive Parts A and B benefits, offered by private companies approved by Medicare. Often bundles in Part D.
Part D	Prescription Drug Coverage	Helps cover the cost of prescription medications, offered through private plans approved by Medicare.

Most people qualify for Part A premium-free based on work history. Part B, Part C, and Part D typically involve monthly premiums that vary by plan and location.

Original Medicare vs. Medicare Advantage

There are two main paths for getting your Medicare benefits. Neither is universally “better” — the right fit depends on your doctors, prescriptions, budget, and travel habits.

Original Medicare (Parts A & B)

- Administered directly by the federal government.
- You can generally see any doctor or hospital that accepts Medicare, nationwide.
- Often paired with a separate Part D drug plan and, optionally, a Medicare Supplement (Medigap) policy.

Medicare Advantage (Part C)

- Offered by private insurance companies approved by Medicare.
- Typically uses a network of doctors and hospitals, similar to an HMO or PPO.
- Often includes extra benefits not covered by Original Medicare, such as vision, dental, or hearing — specifics vary widely by plan.

Medicare Supplement (Medigap)

A Medigap policy is optional supplemental insurance that works alongside Original Medicare to help cover some of the out-of-pocket costs Medicare doesn't pay, like copayments, coinsurance, and deductibles. Medigap plans are standardized by letter (like Plan G or Plan N), so the same lettered plan covers the same benefits no matter which company sells it — though premiums can differ between companies.

Key Enrollment Periods

Timing matters in Medicare. Missing a window can mean waiting months for your next chance — or, in some cases, a lifelong penalty. Here are the main periods to know.

Initial Enrollment Period (IEP)	7 months around your 65th birthday (3 months before, your birthday month, and 3 months after).
Annual Enrollment Period (AEP)	October 15 – December 7 each year. You can switch Medicare Advantage or Part D plans, or move between Original Medicare and Medicare Advantage.
Medicare Advantage Open Enrollment Period (MA OEP)	January 1 – March 31. If you're already in a Medicare Advantage plan, you can switch to a different Medicare Advantage plan or back to Original Medicare.
Special Enrollment Period (SEP)	Triggered by specific life events, such as moving out of your plan's service area or losing other coverage.

A Few Common Mistakes to Avoid

- Assuming your plan automatically renews with the same coverage and costs — plans can change year to year.
- Missing the Initial Enrollment Period, which can lead to delayed coverage or penalties in some cases.
- Not checking whether your doctors and prescriptions are covered before switching plans.
- Choosing a plan based on premium alone, without looking at the full picture of costs and coverage.

Questions Worth Asking Before You Decide

- Are my current doctors and hospitals in this plan's network?
- Are my prescriptions covered, and at what cost?
- What is the maximum I could pay out-of-pocket in a year?
- Does this plan work if I travel or split time between states?
- What happens if I need to change plans later?

This guide is educational and general in nature. It is not a comparison of specific plans, and it is not an offer, solicitation, or endorsement of any particular plan or carrier. Your actual costs and coverage depend on the specific plan you choose.

Have Questions? Let's Talk It Through.

This guide covers the basics, but every situation is different. As a local, independent agent, Bryant represents multiple insurance companies — so the conversation starts with your needs, not one company's product. There's no cost and no obligation to talk.

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Bryant Waldron Insurance is not connected with or endorsed by the U.S. government or the federal Medicare program.

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